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OLD FOES Former Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot; right, Congress leader Sachin Pilot

report is proof that the alleged BJP-Pilot conspiracy was more fiction than fact, a plot conjured up by Gehlot to sully an internal revolt by the then deputy CM.

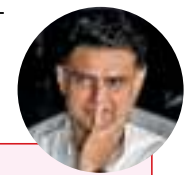
Gehlot's counter? That of the many FIRs filed then, the gravest one still pending with the ACB. This involves another of the audio clips circulated by Gehlot's then OSD (and now bitter critic) Lokesh Sharma. Here, it's directly alleged that Union minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat is speaking with Congressmen—then minister Vishvendra Singh, MLA Bhanwarlal Sharma (since deceased)—besides businessman Sanjay Jain.

PLOT AND COUNTER-PLOT

Gehlot first alleged a plot in June 2020, fearing a repeat of MP where the BJP had toppled Kamal Nath's regime with Jyotiraditya Scindia's help. His loyalist and then water resources minister Mahesh Joshi—now jailed by the ED on an alleged scam in the Jal Jeevan Mission—lodged complaints with the ACB and the Special Operations Group (SOG), citing the phone conversations and listing suspect numbers. That July, the SOG made two arrests; the HC order in this case has reopened the controversy, slapping charges of conspiracy and sedition, while seeking Gehlot and Pilot's statements.

Pilot revolted soon after, moving his MLAs to a Gurgaon resort; Gehlot shifted his flock to Jaipur. Joshi got another FIR filed, submitting new recordings that named one 'Gajendra Singh'. Amidst more arrests, the Centre hinted at handing the sedition-linked probe to the NIA. That got Gehlot's police to apply brakes; in August, sedition charges were dropped and all FIRs were transferred to the ACB.

Gehlot traces the report exoneration to "pressure", and says the surviving ACB case is stalled because Shekhawat refuses to give a voice sample. Critics point to how the ACB, under Gehlot, couldn't nail even the first case for three years. Accused by Gehlot of masterminding the coup, Shekhawat, too, has seized upon the closure as vindication. "The case against me was a lie," he declares. He has had an FIR filed in Delhi alleging illegal phone-tapping under Gehlot.



Takeaways

- **HC finds the petitions to quash FIR infructuous, given the closure report pending before the trial court**
- **That reignites hostilities, with Gehlot camp alleging BJP plot to weaken him**

Gehlot already faces a defamation case from Shekhawat over the alleged Sanjeevani Cooperative scam, where the ex-CM had accused the Union minister of duping investors. The SOG had given Shekhawat a clean chit.

To Gehlot's camp, the selective closure of cases reflects a BJP strategy to weaken him, perhaps even with the objective of subtly keeping Pilot in play as a challenger to him within the Congress. True or not, the Congress's inner dynamic will be worth watching. ■

▶ KARNATAKA

THE CASTE

Siddaramaiah's second caste sur



By **Ajay Sukumaran**

A TUMULTUOUS START. That's what Karnataka's latest attempt to map the socio-economic conditions of Other Backward Classes (OBCs) got off to on September 22. Depending on how the weather conditions develop, the question is whether it will elude the fate of its predecessor—the 2015 caste survey conducted during Siddaramaiah's first term as CM, whose findings took ten years to see the light of day. Or will Karnataka be able and willing to produce some-